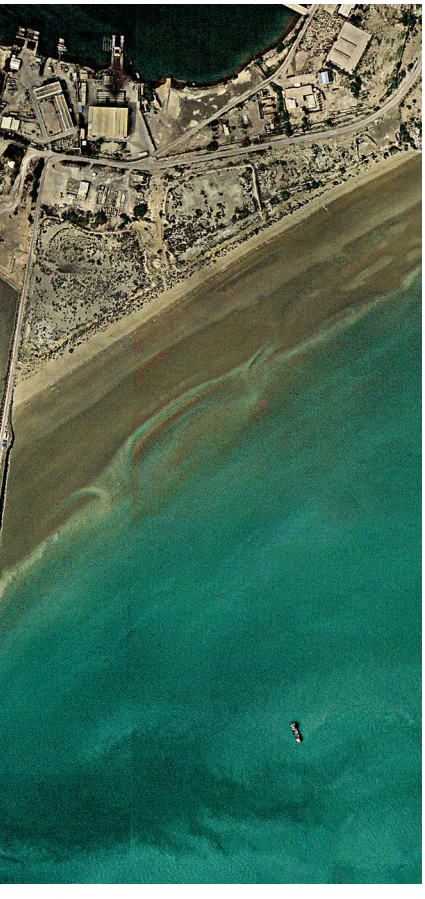


INTRACTABLE TOLL Funerals after an airstrike at a girls' school in Minab, Iran, Mar. 2



EX-DIPLOMAT S. AKBARUDDIN SAYS YOU CAN'T BRING REGIME CHANGE BY BOMBING INSTALLATIONS, YOU HAVE TO PUT BOOTS ON THE GROUND

air bases, to force them to press Trump to wind down the war. The second is to internationalise the conflict by imposing costs on the global economy, particularly via the Strait of Hormuz.

However, this strategy has risks of its own. Rather than fracturing the coalition against it, Iran's attacks have, in some cases, pushed Gulf states closer to the US while drawing European powers into the crisis. The risks also radiate outward. Raja Karthikeya, a former international civil servant who worked recently in Iran, points to a wildcard scenario that he describes as "a wider economic shock, driven by disruptions to oil markets or global trade, that forces major powers and heavily affected countries to demand that the US end the conflict".

Experts say the best-case scenario would be a peaceful evolution from a theocratic dictatorship to some form of representative government, though they say the chances of this are remote. A second possibility is a civil war scenario that could lead to some degree of state fragmentation, akin to what happened in Iraq. There is also talk of Americans and Israelis arming separatist groups in Iran to take out its border security and protection infrastructure. They are said to be working with factions among the Azeris, who form 15 per cent of Iran's population, and the Kurds, who account for 10 per cent, encouraging them to weaken the control of the central government, particularly over its territorial integrity. Iran has already conducted cross-border strikes into Iraq, targeting some of these separatist bases. At the same time, the brutal crackdown on protesters in January has served as a deterrent for many groups that might otherwise contemplate an internal revolt.

The absolute worst-case scenario is a regional conflagration that could see millions of people on the move in the region and set the Gulf states back by decades. But Syed Akbaruddin, India's former Permanent Representative to the UN, cites factors that could impede escalation. He points in particular to the Gulf nations, which have economic and political stakes in regional stability, and little long-term interest in letting the conflict fester. Prolonged hostilities, he notes, will permanently damage the Gulf's reputation of being a safe harbour for business. Akbaruddin also points out that regime change rarely happens through air strikes. "You can't just bomb installations or kill a few people," he says. "You will have to put boots on the ground, and you will have to go into Iran and remove the regime."

BOOTS ON THE GROUND

Trump spooked many in his MAGA base when he said he would not rule out the "boots on the ground" option in the ongoing Iran conflict. He also unsettled business leaders by suggesting that the war could last more than four weeks. For a president who came to power promising to end "never-ending wars", avoid getting America involved in future wars and to keep its soldiers out of harm's way, this sounded like a puzzling U-turn. Williams blanches at the suggestion of